
“God won’t let master Lincoln beat the South till he does the right thing.”

HARRIET TUBMAN ON LINCOLN’S INITIAL RELUCTANCE TO EMANCIPATE SLAVES, 1862

As with many enslaved people, the exact date of Tubman’s birth is not known. What is certain is that she was born Araminta (“Minty”) Ross on a plantation in Dorchester County, Maryland. She often found herself in the wrong place at the wrong time and was beaten by her enslaver, Edward Brodess, who saw Minty as a nuisance and regularly hired her out to other abusive neighbors. Gaining a strong sense of self-reliance, she grew fearless in the face of physical punishment.

One day, while Minty was running an errand in a local dry goods store, an overseer from another plantation demanded she help restrain an enslaved person who had tried to run away. Tubman refused and the person broke free, running out of the store. While trying to stop him, the overseer threw a two-pound metal weight from the counter. The weight hit Minty’s forehead, fracturing her skull, and for the rest of her life she suffered from severe headaches, seizures, and deep sleeps from which no one could wake her. During these episodes she claimed to commune with the divine and learn God’s intentions for her life.

In 1844, Minty married freedman John Tubman, and took her mother’s name, Harriet. She escaped from enslavement in 1849, and resolved to bring as many kinsmen to freedom as possible.

Passport to freedom

Maryland’s shore was only 90 miles (145km) from Pennsylvania, and with her intimate knowledge of the swamps, estuaries, and